



The World Cup

More than just football?

Every four years, one tournament stops the world — and it means far more than the score.



Listen to the article

Scan the QR code or visit the link.



Fans celebrate as the World Cup trophy is lifted in front of a packed stadium.

WARM-UP

Discuss the questions with a partner.

1. Do you watch the World Cup or other big sporting events? Who do you support?
2. Why do you think sport can bring people together?

Every four years, something remarkable happens. For one month, people who have never kicked a ball gather around screens in homes, cafés, and public squares, united by a single **tournament**. Strangers hug after a goal; entire nations hold their breath together. The World Cup is football, but it is also something much larger.

No other event draws an audience like it. Around half the planet watches some part of the competition, and more than a billion people may see a single final. Part of the appeal is the sheer **spectacle** — the color, the noise, the drama of a penalty shoot-out. But it is also the **rivalry** between nations that, for ninety minutes, matters more than almost anything else.

Hosting the World Cup is a huge undertaking. Countries spend billions of dollars building stadiums, hotels, and transport, hoping the world's attention will boost tourism and pride. Yet the results are mixed. Some new stadiums are used for years; others sit empty once the crowds go home. The **legacy** of hosting can be a gift or a costly burden.

Critics argue the tournament has become too commercial, and that the cost of **hosting** often falls on ordinary people. Supporters reply that few things unite the world so powerfully — that for a few weeks, borders seem to matter a little less.

For one month every four years, the whole world seems to watch the same thing. Why does that still matter?

VOCABULARY

A. Match the words (1–5) with their meanings (A–E).

- | | |
|-----------------|--|
| 1. spectacle — | A. strong competition between two sides |
| 2. tournament — | B. something left behind that lasts |
| 3. rivalry — | C. a competition with many teams or games |
| 4. host — | D. to hold and organize an event |
| 5. legacy — | E. an impressive public show or sight |

TRUE OR FALSE

Read the statements and circle T (True) or F (False).

- | | |
|---|-------------------|
| 1. About half the planet watches some part of the World Cup. | T F |
| 2. Every new World Cup stadium is used for many years afterwards. | T F |
| 3. Hosting the World Cup costs billions of dollars. | T F |
| 4. Some critics say the tournament has become too commercial. | T F |
| 5. The article says the World Cup is only about football. | T F |

DISCUSSION

- 1 Do you enjoy watching the World Cup or big sporting events? Why or why not?
- 2 Has a sporting event ever brought your country or family together?
- 3 Why do people feel such strong emotions about their national team?
- 4 Is spending billions to host the World Cup worth it? Why or why not?
- 5 Does the World Cup still bring the world together, or divide it?



01 CRITICAL THINKING

WAS IT WORTH IT?

Six things a country buys when it hosts a World Cup. Which were worth the money?

Mark each one **WORTH IT** or **NOT**. You have to agree as a group, and be ready to say who paid.

WHAT THEY GOT	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE FIVE YEARS LATER	WORTH IT	NOT
A \$200M stadium	Beautiful, and now home to a third-division team who fill a tenth of it.	☐	☐
A new metro line	Built for the fans. Used every morning by people who never bought a ticket.	☐	☐
A month of attention	The whole world learned the country's name. Tourism rose, then settled back.	☐	☐
40,000 jobs	Real wages for two years. Almost all of them ended the week after the final.	☐	☐
The debt	Still being repaid by people who were children during the tournament.	☐	☐
One national memory	A goal the whole country watched together. Nobody can put a price on it.	☐	☐

YOUR VERDICT Worth it overall? _____ Would you vote yes for your own city? _____

- DISCUSS**
- 1 Can a memory be worth a debt your children pay?
 - 2 Compare with another group. Who said yes to their own city, and why?

02 LANGUAGE IN CONTEXT

USE THE LANGUAGE

Complete each sentence with a word from the box. Change the form if you need to.

host legacy tournament rivalry spectacle

- 1 The final was an amazing _____ that no one will forget.
- 2 There is a fierce _____ between the two teams.
- 3 Our country hopes to _____ the next World Cup.
- 4 A great event can leave a lasting _____.
- 5 A knockout _____ can be decided by a single goal.

04 WRITING

YOUR OPINION

Should countries spend billions of dollars to host the World Cup?

Write 150–200 words, using ideas and vocabulary from the article.

03 SPEAKING CHALLENGE

ROLE • TASK • PRESENT

In small groups, work through the three steps below.

- | | |
|----------------|---|
| ROLE | You are on your city's committee bidding to host the World Cup. |
| TASK | Agree on three reasons your city would be a great host. |
| PRESENT | Present your bid and explain why your city deserves it. |